

Unit 4: Jacobean Tragedy and Thomas Middleton

4.1 Jacobean Tragedy / Drama (The Genre)

While Jacobean comedies mocked the greed and tricks of the London streets, **Jacobean Tragedy** explored the dark, psychological underbelly of human nature, royal courts, and high society. Written during the reign of King James I (1603–1625), these tragedies moved away from the heroic, grand style of Elizabethan plays and dove straight into themes of moral decay, sexual corruption, political instability, and revenge.

Key Features of Jacobean Tragedy:

- **Dark and Cynical Atmosphere:** The tone of these plays is pessimistic. The playwrights portray a world where goodness is rare, and characters are driven by raw ambition, lust, and greed.
- **The Italian Setting:** Jacobean playwrights frequently set their tragedies in Italian courts (like Florence or Venice). To the English audience of the time, Italy symbolized a place of absolute political corruption, secret poisonings, and unchecked passion.
- **Sexual Politics and Lust:** Unlike traditional historical tragedies centered only on kings losing their crowns, Jacobean tragedy often placed sexual desire, forced marriages, adultery, and domestic betrayal at the absolute center of the plot.
- **Sensationalism and Violence:** The plays are highly theatrical and shocking. They often feature complex revenge plots, executions, torture, and a high body count in the final scenes.

4.1.1 Thomas Middleton (The Playwright)

Thomas Middleton (1580–1627) was one of the most prolific and brilliant dramatists of the Jacobean era. He excelled at writing both sharp city comedies and psychological tragedies.

- **The Realist Observer:** Middleton looked at human behavior without romanticizing it. He wrote about people as they were—flawed, easily tempted, and highly transactional.
- **Master of Deep Psychology:** While other writers focused on ghosts and monsters, Middleton's terror came from the human mind. He specialized in showing how ordinary people slowly compromise their morals until they become capable of terrible crimes.
- **Focus on Gender and Society:** As seen in his titles, Middleton was deeply interested in the status of women in Jacobean society. He highlighted how women were treated as property, bought and sold in marriages, and how they fought back using manipulation when denied legal power.

4.1.1.1 Women Beware Women

"Women Beware Women" (written around 1621, published in 1657) is Thomas Middleton's supreme tragic masterpiece. The title acts as a warning: it suggests that in a corrupt patriarchal world, women often become the agents who betray, manipulate, and destroy other women.

Core Plot Concept:

Set in the wealthy court of Florence, the play tracks two parallel stories of moral decay. The first follows **Leantio**, a poor clerk, who secretly marries a wealthy Venetian beauty named **Bianca**. When the powerful **Duke of Florence** sees Bianca, he desires her and uses an aristocratic woman named **Livia** to manipulate and seduce her.

The second plot follows Livia's brother, **Fabritio**, who forces his innocent daughter, **Isabella**, into a marriage with a rich but foolish Ward. To comfort Isabella, Livia lies to her, claiming that her true love—her uncle **Hippolito**—is not biologically related to her, leading them into an incestuous relationship.

Detailed Character List

The First Plot Line (The Seduction of Bianca):

- **Leantio**: A young, low-wage factor (clerk) in Florence. He is deeply insecure about his poverty and treats his new wife, Bianca, like a prized treasure he must hide away.
- **Bianca**: A beautiful, aristocratic young woman from Venice who elopes with Leantio out of romantic idealism, but quickly grows tired of living in poverty.
- **The Duke of Florence**: The absolute ruler of Florence. Power-hungry and lustful, he believes his royal status gives him the right to take whatever he desires, including another man's wife.

The Second Plot Line (The Betrayal of Isabella):

- **Isabella**: Livia's young, innocent niece. She wants to be a loyal daughter but is trapped by a corrupt society that views her as a financial asset.
- **Hippolito**: Livia and Fabritio's brother. He feels intense guilt over his romantic lust for his niece Isabella, yet he lacks the moral strength to stop himself.
- **The Ward**: A wealthy, young, foolish heir. He is incredibly vulgar and treats the prospect of inspecting his future bride like buying a horse.

The Master Manipulator:

- **Livia**: A wealthy, highly intelligent widow. She is the psychological engine of the play. She uses her brilliant wit, charm, and social power to arrange the downfall of both Bianca and Isabella, acting as the ultimate court matchmaker and corrupter.

Plot Summary Act-by-Act

Act 1: The Illusion of Romantic Love

Leantio arrives at his modest home in Florence, bringing his new bride, Bianca, whom he has stolen away from her wealthy family in Venice. Leantio's mother warns him that a rich girl will quickly grow unhappy with poor food and plain rooms, but the lovers insist their affection is enough. Meanwhile, in the upper-class world, Fabritio is busy arranging a wealthy marriage between his daughter, Isabella, and the foolish Ward. Isabella is horrified but helpless.

Act 2: The Chess Game and Seduction

This Act features one of the most famous allegorical scenes in English drama. The Duke sees Bianca during a public procession and resolves to have her. He asks Livia for help.

- Livia invites Leantio's mother to her palace to play a game of chess. While the mother is distracted by the game on the lower floor, Livia's servants guide Bianca upstairs.
- Upstairs, the Duke confronts Bianca. He alternates between threatening his absolute power and promising her immense wealth, luxury, and protection. Bianca yields to the temptation.
- When Bianca returns downstairs, the chess game ends. The dialogue is full of double meanings; as Livia wins the chess pieces, the Duke has won Bianca's virtue.

Act 3: The Shift to Corruption

Bianca returns to Leantio's small house completely changed. She mocks the cheap furniture, demands luxury, and refuses to be hidden away. Soon, the Duke sends an official invitation offering Leantio a political promotion to send him away, while taking Bianca to live openly at the palace as the royal mistress.

In the parallel plot, Livia pities her brother Hippolito's secret love for Isabella. To break Isabella's resistance, Livia lies to her, claiming she was born out of an affair and that Hippolito is not her real uncle. Believing this lie, Isabella agrees to marry the foolish Ward to protect her social reputation, while secretly starting a passionate affair with Hippolito.

Act 4: The Cycle of Revenge

Leantio is devastated by the loss of his wife and his ruined honor. To mock Bianca, he accepts the romantic advances of the wealthy Livia, becoming her kept lover. When Bianca sees Leantio dressed in fine clothes paid for by Livia, she tells the Duke. The Duke, wanting to clear the path to marry Bianca legally, tells Hippolito about the shameful affair between his sister Livia and the poor clerk Leantio. Enraged by the dishonor to his family name, Hippolito challenges Leantio to a duel and brutally kills him.

Act 5: The Deadly Masque (The Climax)

Hearing of Leantio's death, Livia is heartbroken and wild with rage. To get revenge on her brother Hippolito, she reveals the secret incestuous affair between him and Isabella to the entire court.

The play concludes during a grand celebratory *Masque* (a courtly theatrical performance) organized to celebrate the wedding of the Duke and Bianca. Every character uses the performance to stage a real murder:

- Isabella uses burning incense to poison Livia during the play.
- Livia, dressed as a goddess, uses a trapdoor to unleash lethal gold smoke that chokes Isabella to death.
- Hippolito is shot with poisoned arrows by court actors. In his agonizing death throes, he runs onto his own sword.
- The Cardinal (the Duke's holy brother) tries to warn the Duke about his sins. In a tragic mix-up, Bianca tries to poison the Cardinal with a cup of wine, but the Duke drinks it instead and dies.
- Seeing her royal lover dead and her ambitions destroyed, Bianca drinks the remaining poison from the cup and falls dead over the Duke's body.

Important Themes for Exams:

1. **The Transactional Nature of Society:** Middleton shows a world where everything—marriage, love, religion, and human loyalty—is treated as a financial commodity to be bought, sold, or traded.

2. **Moral Slippage (Gradual Decay):** The tragedy highlights how characters do not start out evil. Bianca begins as an innocent bride, but once exposed to wealth and corruption, she quickly adapts to become a cold, calculating court player.
3. **Women as Oppressors of Women:** Reflecting the title, the play critiques how patriarchal structures force women to compete against and exploit each other. Livia uses her freedom and intellect not to help young women like Bianca and Isabella, but to trap them for the pleasure of men.